MONGOL ARMS

Most Mongol mounted archers were simply equipped, but the minority of elite warriors, carrying lances and other close-quarters weapons, were more elaborately kitted out. In 1246 a papal ambassador to the Great Khan described the Mongol lancers as having "helms and cuirasses of leather ... made of strips about a palm broad, sewn together so that they overlap". Mongols adopted richly decorated weaponry, largely influenced by civilizations they conquered, especially China.



Helmet and armour
Armour was worn by the Mongols' elite warriors who were expected to engage the enemy at close quarters. Like the armour of Japanese samurai, it was made of hardened leather plates sewn together. This lamellar armour offered a high degree of protection relative to its weight, allowing full mobility. The Mongols' helmets were most often made of iron, but, as here, could also be of leather.





TWIN DAGGERS



IRON MACE

Close-quarters weapons
The elaborate decoration that adorns the 14th- century mace *(left)* suggests that it would have served a warrior of high status, almost certainly a member of a khan's personal entourage. The two small daggers, featuring silver blades and ivory handles, were also luxury products. A dagger might be employed to finish off a wounded enemy, but would also have many everyday uses.

